Beginner-friendly guide | 16 sections | Interactive + printable

A visual, step-by-step journey from human text to Transformer predictions—from tokens and embeddings through attention, training, retrieval, and tool use.

Understand the complete pipeline without needing advanced mathematics.

1. The one-minute mental model

A modern large language model is a stack of learned pattern-matching layers. It converts text into tokens, maps each token to a vector, repeatedly lets every token gather information from other tokens, and finally predicts a probability distribution for the next token.

Text → Tokens → Embeddings → Transformer layers → Logits → Next token

The model does not look up a stored answer. It repeatedly estimates what should come next from patterns learned during training.

2. Tokens: the model’s actual input

Text is first divided into token IDs using a tokenizer. A token may be a common word, a word fragment, punctuation, or a byte sequence. This is why models can handle unfamiliar names and code: the vocabulary contains reusable pieces rather than only complete words.

Stage	Example	What the model receives
Raw text	“Neural networks learn patterns.”	Characters
Tokenization	“Neural networks learn patterns .”	Token IDs
Embedding lookup	`[182, 4417, 12, 802]`	Four vectors

Tokenization is lossy in a practical sense: different strings can map to the same IDs, and one string can split differently across tokenizers. Context-window limits are also measured in tokens—not words or characters.

3. Embeddings: turning IDs into meaning

Each token ID indexes a learned vector of dimension d_{model}. Initially these vectors are arbitrary. During training, gradient updates reshape nearby vectors so that vectors useful in similar contexts become more alike.

```
X = E[token_ids] + P(position)
```

Mental model: an embedding is not a dictionary definition. It is a learned coordinate system that makes useful operations—similarity, analogy, and attention—computable as vector arithmetic.

Because attention has no inherent notion of sequence order, the original Transformer adds a positional encoding. Modern systems commonly use learned positions or relative techniques such as rotary position embeddings (RoPE).

4. Self-attention: information routing

For each token position, self-attention asks three questions:

1. What information am I looking for? **Query** \(q_i\).
2. What information do I contain? **Key** \(k_i\).
3. How useful is each other token to me? **Value** \(v_i\).

Matrices \(W_Q\), \(W_K\), and \(W_V\) project each input vector:

```
Q = XW_Q,   K = XW_K,   V = XW_V
```

For a query position \(i\), compare its query with every key:

$$s_{ij} = (q_i \cdot k_j) / \sqrt{d_k}$$
$$\alpha_{ij} = \text{softmax}_j(s_{ij})$$
$$z_i = \Sigma_j \alpha_{ij} v_j$$

The dot product measures compatibility. Softmax turns scores into positive weights that sum to one. The weighted sum of values therefore becomes a context-aware summary.

5. Worked attention example

Suppose a model reads “The animal did not cross the street because it was tired.” For the token it, useful context includes “animal,” “cross,” and “tired.” Attention computes a separate mixture of values for every position; it does not select one token permanently.

Token	Key compatibility with query “it”	Attention weight	What its value contributes
animal	0.82	0.39	Who performed the action
cross	0.51	0.15	What happened
street	0.27	0.08	Location
tired	0.73	0.23	Reason or state

The numbers are illustrative. Real attention scores emerge from learned projections and change with the input, layer, and head.

6. Multi-head attention: parallel relationship detectors

One attention pattern cannot express every relationship equally well. Multi-head attention runs several smaller attention systems in parallel. Each head can specialize in a different relationship—syntax, nearby references, rare lexical matches, or broader semantic links.

$$\text{head}_h = \text{Attention}(XW_{Q,h}, XW_{K,h}, XW_{V,h})$$
$$\text{MultiHead}(X) = \text{Concat}(\text{head}_1, \ldots, \text{head}_H)W_O$$

The concatenated heads are mixed by an output projection. Heads are not guaranteed to become human-readable specialists, but inspecting them often reveals useful recurring patterns.

Head A

Links it to the subject earlier in the sentence.

Head B

Connects verbs with their associated objects.

Head C

Tracks long-distance semantic relationships.

7. Residual connections, normalization, and the feed-forward network

A Transformer block is not just attention. It also uses residual connections, normalization, and a position-wise feed-forward network. Residual paths preserve information and make deep networks easier to optimize.

$$x \leftarrow x + \mathrm{Attention}(\mathrm{LayerNorm}(x))$$
$$x \leftarrow x + \mathrm{FFN}(\mathrm{LayerNorm}(x))$$
$$\mathrm{FFN}(x) = W_2\,\sigma(W_1 x + b_1) + b_2$$

The feed-forward network applies the same small neural network independently to every token. It can expand each vector into a higher-dimensional space, apply a nonlinear activation, and project it back. Attention moves information between positions; the feed-forward network transforms each position's features after information exchange.

> Modern implementations vary the ordering and form of normalization—for example, pre-norm versus post-norm. The core ideas remain the same: attention, residual pathways, normalization, and nonlinear feature transformation.

8. Training: how the model learns

Training combines two broad ideas: supervised learning and self-supervised next-token prediction. Given a sequence, the model predicts a masked or next token; a loss function measures how wrong its probability distribution was; backpropagation computes how each parameter contributed; and an optimizer updates the parameters.

```
loss = −Σ log P(x_t | x_<t)
```

At first, predictions are nearly random. Across billions or more examples and many optimization steps, repeated small adjustments cause useful statistical patterns to emerge.

Stage	What happens
Forward pass	The model converts tokens into predictions.
Loss	Predictions are compared with expected targets.
Backward pass	Gradients are propagated through the computation graph.
Update	An optimizer such as AdamW adjusts the weights.

“Training a model” therefore means optimizing millions to hundreds of billions of parameters. The objective rewards useful next-token predictions; broad capabilities can emerge from learning many such local statistical tasks.

9. Inference: from logits to a response

The final projection converts the model's final hidden vector into one logit for every vocabulary item. A softmax turns those logits into probabilities. During generation, the system chooses tokens repeatedly and appends each new token to the context.

```
logits = hW_vocab
P(token_j) = exp(logit_j) / Σ exp(logit_i)
```

Generation may be greedy—choose the highest-probability token—or use sampling with temperature, top-p, or top-k. Greedy decoding is deterministic; sampling can produce varied outputs but may select less probable tokens.

Important distinction: a model's generated response may include claims that were not directly present in its context. Plausible wording does not prove factual correctness. Retrieval-augmented generation can add external information, but retrieval quality and prompt design still affect the result.

10. Capabilities and limitations: why models can sound intelligent

Large models compress recurring linguistic structure, concepts, reasoning patterns, styles, and task formats into billions of learned parameters. They can therefore reuse a learned pattern in a novel context. This explains strong performance on writing, translation, coding, extraction, and many question-answering tasks.

They also inherit the structure and noise of their training data. Fluent errors, fabricated citations, biased patterns, prompt sensitivity, and brittleness are possible because fluent continuation and guaranteed truth are different objectives.

Strengths

Fast synthesis, broad task coverage, context-aware transformation, and useful pattern matching.

Limits

No inherent truth detector, finite context, uneven factual reliability, and possible reasoning failures.

Best use

A capable assistant for drafting, analysis, learning, and tool use—with verification for consequential claims.

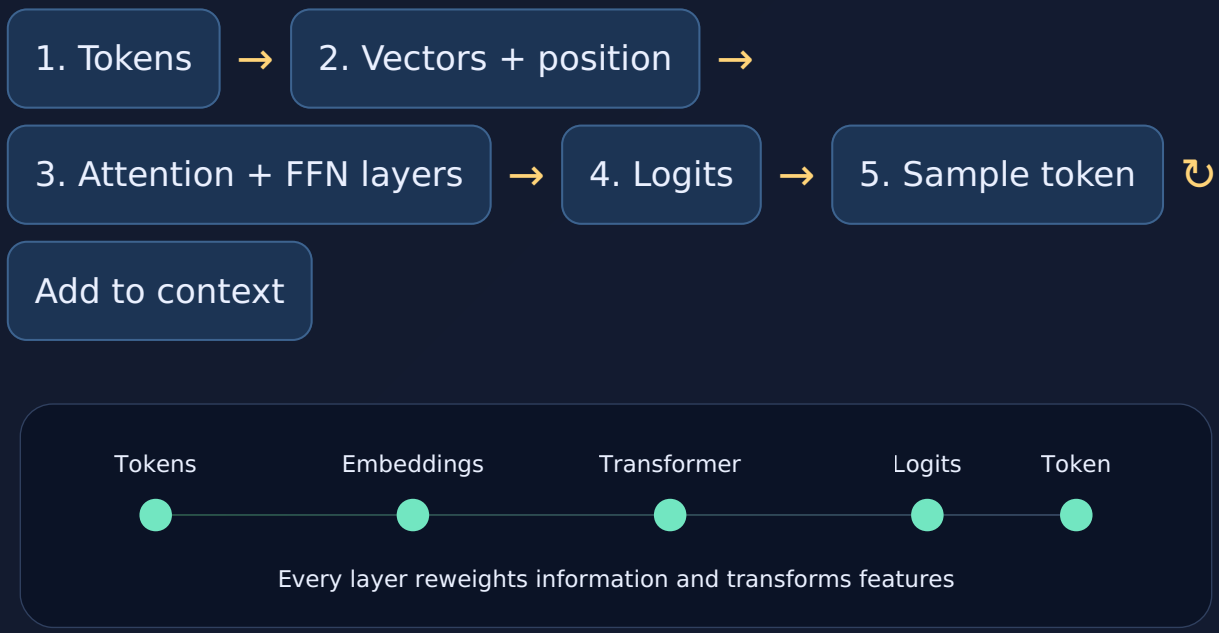
11. A practical workflow for reliable use

1. State the task, audience, constraints, and output format precisely.
2. Provide the necessary context and distinguish facts from assumptions.

3. Ask for a step-by-step solution or structured intermediate output when reasoning matters.
4. Use tools for current facts, calculations, retrieval, and execution.
5. Verify critical claims, numbers, citations, and code.
6. Iterate by correcting specific errors rather than merely asking for “a better answer.”

A strong prompt is not a magical spell. It is a compact specification that reduces ambiguity and gives the model enough information to apply its learned capabilities.

12. Visual recap of the whole pipeline



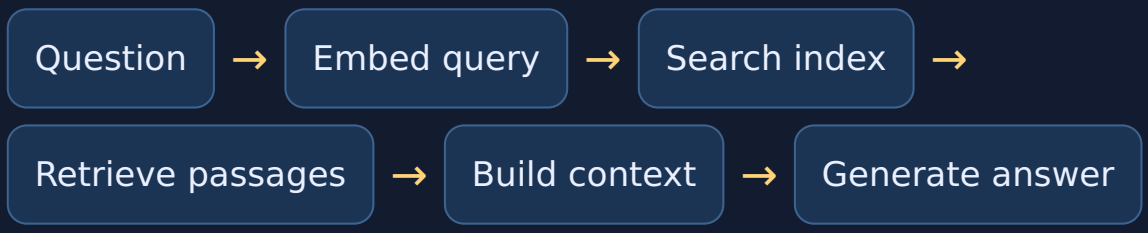
13. Trusted references

- Vaswani et al., “Attention Is All You Need” — the original Transformer paper.
- Jay Alammar, “The Illustrated Transformer” — visual explanation of encoder, decoder, attention, and embeddings.

- Alexander Rush, “The Annotated Transformer” — a line-by-line PyTorch implementation and training walkthrough.

14. Retrieval-augmented generation: giving the model current context

A language model’s parameters contain compressed patterns learned during training. They do not automatically contain every recent fact, private document, or live database record. Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) adds an external information step before generation.



The retriever searches a vector database or hybrid keyword-and-vector index. Relevant passages are inserted into the prompt alongside the user’s question. The Transformer then conditions its next-token predictions on both.

Component	Function	Common failure
Embedding model	Maps text and queries into comparable vectors.	Weak equivalence across specialized terminology.
Index	Stores vectors, text chunks, and metadata.	Stale, duplicated, or poorly segmented documents.
Retriever	Selects candidate passages by relevance.	Correct answer missing from top results.
Generator	Produces an answer grounded in supplied passages.	Ignores evidence, mixes sources, or fabricates details.

RAG does not change the model's weights. It changes the information available at inference time. Its quality therefore depends on document quality, chunking, ranking, context construction, and answer verification—not only on the LLM.

15. Tool use: turning text generation into action

Tools extend what an AI system can do by connecting the model to external capabilities: web search, databases, calculators, code execution, email, and business APIs. The model does not execute code itself. It emits a structured request that an orchestration layer validates and runs.

1. The application describes available tools and their schemas to the model.
2. The model emits a tool call with a tool name and structured arguments.

3. The runtime validates permissions, argument types, limits, and safety policy.
4. The tool executes and returns a result—often serialized as JSON.
5. The result is added to the conversation or model context.
6. The model uses the result to continue reasoning or produce the final answer.

16. Trusted references for retrieval and tools

- IBM, “What is retrieval-augmented generation?” — overview of the RAG architecture and its practical benefits.
- Model Context Protocol documentation — an open protocol for connecting AI applications to external tools and data sources.